MSc Masters Project Final Report Guidance

The MSc masters project final report represents the culmination of your postgraduate studies. It is your opportunity to bring together the knowledge, methods, and critical thinking skills developed throughout your programme and apply them to a substantial piece of independent work. Whether you are completing an individual project or contributing to a group project, the masters project final report demonstrates your ability to investigate a topic in depth, justify your decisions, and communicate your findings with clarity and academic rigour.

The masters project final report allows you to explore a topic that genuinely interests you, engage with real-world problems or research questions, and show that you can plan, manage, and deliver a complex project. It also requires you to evaluate existing research, select appropriate tools and techniques, and present your ideas and results in a structured and coherent way.

Purpose of the MSc Masters Project Final Report

The masters project final report is designed to assess your ability to undertake independent research and produce a substantial academic report and **constitutes weightage of 60% of total module mark**. It enables you to demonstrate intellectual curiosity, creativity, and technical competence. You are expected to show that you can manage your time effectively, make informed decisions, and critically reflect on your work. The project is also an opportunity to showcase your communication skills by presenting your findings in a clear and persuasive manner.

Marking Scheme

The masters project final report is assessed using the following marking structure:

- Introduction – 5%
- Literature Review – 15%
- Research Design – 15%
- Implementation – 25%
- Testing – 10%
- Presentation of Results – 10%
- Conclusions – 10%
- Critical Self-Evaluation – 10%

Each section contributes to the overall quality of your masters project final report. Strong performance requires not only technical achievement but also clarity of explanation, critical insight, and a well-structured narrative.

Masters Project Final Report Length and Structure

The structure of your masters project final report will depend on whether you are completing an individual project or working as part of a group. In both cases, the report should be written in a formal academic style and should follow a logical progression from introduction to conclusion.

Individual Project

An individual masters project final report is typically around 15,000 words. This word count includes all main chapters but excludes appendices and references. The structure usually follows the sequence below:

- Introduction – Outlines the project aims, context, and motivation.
- Literature Review – Demonstrates your understanding of existing research and situates your work within it.
- Research Design – Explains your chosen methodology and justifies your approach.
- Implementation – Describes how you carried out the project and the tools or techniques used.
- Testing – Presents the evaluation of your system, model, or approach.
- Presentation of Results – Summarises your findings clearly and accurately.
- Conclusions – Reflects on what has been achieved and the significance of your work.
- Critical Self-Evaluation – Discusses your performance, decision-making, and areas for improvement.

Group Project (Four Members)

A group project combines collaborative work **with individual assessment components**. The total masters project final report length is approximately 15,000 words, divided as follows:

Group Sections (~10,000 words): These chapters describe the shared project work. They should clearly explain the overall aims, background, design, implementation, and testing of the group's solution. It is essential to highlight each member's contribution within these sections so that individual roles are transparent.

Individual Sections (~5,000 words per student): Each student must independently write their own Presentation of Results, Conclusions, and Critical Self-Evaluation. These sections allow you to demonstrate your personal understanding of the project outcomes, your ability to interpret results, and your capacity for reflective analysis.

Writing Each Section Effectively

Introduction

The introduction should set the scene for your project. It explains what the project is about, why it matters, and what you aim to achieve. A strong introduction provides a clear sense of direction and helps the reader understand the purpose and scope of your work.

Literature Review

This section shows that you understand the academic and professional context of your project. You should discuss key theories, methods, and findings from existing research, highlighting gaps or limitations that your project addresses. The review should be analytical rather than descriptive, demonstrating your ability to compare and evaluate different sources.

Research Design

Here you explain how you approached the project. You should justify your choice of methodology, tools, and techniques, and show how these decisions support your aims. A well-written research design section demonstrates that your approach is logical, feasible, and grounded in established practice.

Implementation

This chapter describes how you carried out the project. It should provide enough detail for someone else to understand your process and replicate your work if needed. You should explain the steps you took, the challenges you encountered, and how you addressed them.

Testing

Testing is essential for demonstrating that your solution works as intended. You should describe the tests you performed, the criteria you used, and the outcomes you observed. This section should be clear, systematic, and evidence-based.

Presentation of Results

Your results should be presented in a clear and organised manner. You may use tables, figures, or diagrams to support your explanations. The focus should be on helping the reader understand what you discovered and why it matters.

Conclusions

The conclusion summarises the key achievements of your project and reflects on their significance. You should revisit your aims and explain how they were met. This section should also highlight the broader implications of your work and suggest possible directions for future research.

Critical Self-Evaluation

This section requires honest reflection on your performance throughout the project. You should discuss what you did well, what you found challenging, and what you would do differently in future. A thoughtful self-evaluation demonstrates maturity, self-awareness, and a commitment to continuous improvement.

Project Process Document

This needs to be submitted as an Appendix of the final report. For group projects, you can produce a combined document for each meeting with your supervisor.

Submitting Your Dissertation

You should aim for approximately 15,000 words in the main body of your dissertation. Substantial blocks of technical material, such as program code, experimental data, questionnaire responses etc. should be placed in appendices – if sections of this type of material are required in the main body to clarify the text, short excerpts can be used. Stylistically, you should use the following guidelines:

Text

1. Line spacing should be 1.5 lines

2. Text size should be 11 point or greater for main body text

3. Plain typefaces should be used. Typically, a sans-serif font (e.g. Arial, Franklyn) is used for headings and a serif font (e.g. Times New Roman, Garamond) for the main body of text. Generally, there should be no more than two fonts used in the main text, although you can use other fonts for, e.g. program code or tables if you wish

Diagrams and Tables

4. You should number diagrams, tables etc, either sequentially or within chapters (e.g. Figure 2.3 is the third diagram in chapter 2)

5. All diagrams should have captions and where appropriate, a reference to their source.

Contents Lists

6. The dissertation pages should be clearly numbered, using a simple consecutive numbering style (i.e. not separate numbering for each chapter)

7. The dissertation should have a main table of contents and separate tables of figures, tables, charts etc. These should be linked to page numbers in the document.

8. There should be a list of References at the end of the main body of the dissertation (before the appendices). See the UWS guide to referencing at:

https://uws-uk.libguides.com/referencing

Within the UWs Library's link you will find a link to a useful ebook called 'Cite Them Right': https://uws-primo.hosted.exlibrisgroup.com/primo-explore/fulldisplay?docid=44PAI_ALMA2145312590003931&vid=44PAI_V1&search_scope=default_scope&tab=default_tab&lang=en_US&context=L&isFrbr=true

(These links are current at time of writing but may change as UWS update their referencing guide.)

Document Layout

9. The general document structure should be:

a) Front sheet (download template from Aula: Final Submission of Project Report/MSc Project - Front sheet for final report)
b) Declaration of originality and use of generative AI (download from Aula: Final Submission of Project Report/ MSc Project – Student Declaration)
c) Dedications (if used)
d) Abstract – no more than 200 words
e) Table of contents
f) Tables of figures, tables, charts etc, if used
g) Body of dissertation
h) References
i) Appendices (with project process document)
j) A copy of your project specification

Electronic Submission & Originality Check

10. You are required to make **two** electronic submissions of your final report:

- one to the module co-ordinator via email
- one to Turnitin via Aula (submit to the FINAL submission point).

When you submit your work to Turnitin, an originality check on your work will be undertaken using the Turnitin software. The dissertation text will be checked against a database of known academic papers, professional publications, websites, books and other students' dissertations for plagiarism. It is **your responsibility** to ensure that the report is free from plagiarism. You may chose to do this by checking your document in Turnitin (use the **draft** submission point

for Turnitin in the MSc Project module on Aula to check your document prior to its final submission).

Whilst the overall similarity % is useful, all Turnitin reports are looked at in detail by the module co-ordinator, supervisor, moderator and external examiner. You should take care to ensure that all sources are <1%. As a general rule of thumb, no overall similarity score should be >10%.

A submitted report which is shown to contain a significant amount of material from other sources will not be marked and your work may be presented to the Academic Integrity panel for consideration. If a significant amount of plagiarism is indicated, you may be subject to disciplinary proceedings.

11. Note that although we provide the on-line service to allow you to check your own work for inadvertently copied material, we do not consider the on-line result as definitive, and will perform other checks for plagiarism if we consider this necessary.

12. After submission of your final report, you must contact your supervisor and moderator to arrange a mutually convenient time to undertake your oral examination (short viva voce). This examination may take place in person or online via Teams/Zoom. This event should, ideally, take place within a week of your final submission date. Your supervisor and moderator may ask you to demonstrate any software you have developed during your project but you are **NOT** required to make a presentation of your project work. Instead, expect to be asked to answer detailed questions on the work you have submitted.

13. Please note that the submission date in Turnitin is NOT necessarily your project submission date. Your submission date will be given on Aula and is a date that is set by the School for the submission of all final MSc project reports.

Guidance on how to write a good Abstract, together with good and poor examples, can be found on Aula.